

## 4. Sensory Inputs (What the Environment Offers)

Use these terms to describe the sensory qualities present in the environment during observation.

*When documenting sensory-related observations, first describe the environment accurately — what sights, sounds, textures, and movement demands were present. Then separately describe how the child responded (see Section 5). This helps identify patterns and plan supports.*

### Auditory Inputs — Sounds in the Environment

|                                        |                                  |                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| loud group noise                       | music playing at high volume     | sudden loud sounds (e.g., alarm, door slamming) |
| background noise (fans, HVAC, hallway) | multiple voices speaking at once | high-pitched sounds                             |
| low-pitched sounds                     | rhythmic sounds                  | unpredictable sounds                            |
| quiet environment                      | near-silent setting              | outdoor noise                                   |
| echoing room acoustics                 | music with percussion            | talking at close range                          |

### Tactile Inputs — Touch & Texture

|                                            |                                          |                                         |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| wet or damp materials (water, paint, glue) | sticky textures (tape, stickers, slime)  | soft textures (playdough, sand, fabric) |
| rough or scratchy textures                 | smooth hard surfaces                     | messy multi-texture materials           |
| light touch from peers or adults           | firm pressure (hugs, squeezes)           | clothing with tags or seams             |
| bare feet on different floor surfaces      | food textures (mushy, crunchy, wet, dry) | temperature variation (warm, cold)      |

### Visual Inputs — What the Child Sees

|                                      |                                       |                             |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| bright overhead fluorescent lighting | natural sunlight through windows      | dim lighting                |
| flickering light sources             | visually busy wall displays           | minimal visual décor        |
| movement of peers or adults nearby   | fast-moving objects or activities     | screens or projected images |
| strong color contrasts               | patterns or repetition in environment |                             |

### Proprioceptive & Vestibular Inputs — Movement & Body Position

|                                                    |                                              |                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| heavy work activities (pushing, pulling, carrying) | climbing structures                          | swinging or rocking equipment                        |
| spinning activities                                | jumping or bouncing surfaces                 | crawling through tunnels or under furniture          |
| carrying weighted items                            | sitting on unstable surface (wobble cushion) | standing or sitting on floor (no chair back support) |
| seated at a table with chair                       | movement-based transitions                   | long periods of required stillness                   |

| Olfactory & Gustatory Inputs – Smell & Taste |                                                 |                             |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| strong food smells at mealtime               | cleaning product scents                         | paint or art material odors |
| outdoor/nature smells                        | mixed food textures and flavors                 | familiar food items         |
| unfamiliar or new food items                 | foods with strong flavors (sour, spicy, bitter) |                             |